

SIPRA DAS



Pulling in Different Directions

DELHI The Indo-US nuclear deal is not the only bone of contention within the UPA. There are other skirmishes that keep the ruling cauldron on the boil despite the show of bonhomie at the UPA's fourth anniversary celebrations last month.

The latest exchange of

hostilities is between the Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) and the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK). Tired of the PMK's constant criticism of his government, Tamil Nadu chief minister and DMK supremo M. Karunanidhi has ended his alliance with the PMK in the state.

The news is equally troubling from the north where the Lalu Prasad Yadav and Ram Vilas Paswan spat is even older than the UPA. The fact that Lalu got the railway portfolio—which Paswan had been eyeing—only added to the latter's angst. The Congress walks a fine line

between the two egos, though with a larger chunk of MPs, Lalu is clearly the favoured one. He has a special equation with 10, Janpath which Paswan, despite all his iftaar diplomacy, cannot match.

Even the disciplined cadres of the Left are not blameless. The CPI, Forward Bloc and the RPI have often differed with the CPM, particularly over its handling of the Nandigram fiasco. However, they unite while taking on the Congress-led Government at the Centre.

The Congress, too, has not hesitated to pass the buck of rising prices on the Agriculture Ministry held by NCP leader Sharad Pawar. In turn, the NCP has attacked the Congress for its faulty policies. Clearly, the nuclear issue, volatile as it is, is not the only point of fissure in the UPA alliance.

by Priya Sahgal

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

Internal security is in a shambles, Darjeeling and Siliguri are in flames, there is chaos in Manipur, but Home Minister Shivraj Patil was busy last week chairing a Group of Ministers' meeting on street vendors.

VOICES



"Forces inside and outside India don't want free, fair and peaceful elections in Kashmir. In the coming months, we'll see more insurgency and violence."

A.K. Antony, defence minister

"There is a case for insulating the poor. There's a much weaker case for insulating the general consumer and very little case for insulating the rich."

Montek Singh Ahluwalia, Planning Commission deputy chairman on inflation

"Can Advani be called a Pakistani infiltrator because he's from Sindh? Most chief ministers of West Bengal were from erstwhile East Bengal. Can they be called infiltrators?"

Pranab Mukherjee, Union external affairs minister

"There is no difference between Jayalalithaa and Narendra Modi. If she is allowed to thrive, Tamil Nadu will become another Gujarat."

Kanimozhi, Rajya Sabha member

"The Government should not think that Gorkhaland is a separatist demand. It is within the framework of the Constitution."

Roshan Giri, Gorkha Janamukti Morcha general secretary

